

Digital Storytelling Project

"Relic Trader - Artificats of a Forgotten Age"

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MAP 810AP - Digital Storytelling

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Quote from Primary Reading:

"All the stories are here, silt-packed and fossil-stored. The book of the world opens anywhere, chronology is one method only and not the best. Clocks are not time. Even radioactive rock-clocks, even gut-spun DNA, can only tell time like a story. [...] 'Tell me the time you say.' And what you really say is 'Tell me a story.'"
Jeanette Winterson.

Quotes from Additional Readings:

"We are one and all storied and storying beings."
Gregory Cajete

The Premise

A digital story told as a game in which the player controls a merchant living in a post-collapse society working as a relic trader.

- Each day visitors approach with items and scrap to trade
- The items that the NPCs come are all things from our world, but reinterpreted through the lens of the society they live in now.
 - Our world is the forgotten age.
 - We learn solely through collecting and examining, nothing will be stated explicitly.

Inspirations

From Software 'Soulsborne' Games

- The story is learned almost entirely through lore which one may read on item descriptions

"Sir Artorias hunted the Darkwraiths, and his sword strikes harder against dark servants."

"The sword can damage ghosts, as it was cursed when Artorias joined a covenant with the creatures of the Abyss."

"Swallowed by the Dark with its master, this sword is tainted by the Abyss, and now its strength reflects its wielder's humanity."

Inspirations

Pikmin 2

- Our alien protagonists discovers things from the human world and gives them amusing names

In Game Name	Real Name
'Cupid's Grenade'	Cherry
'Insect Condo'	Apple
'Child of the Earth'	Potato
'Pastry Wheel'	Donut
'Sud Generator'	Soap

In Game Name	Real Name
'Behemoth Jaw'	Denture
'Joy Receptacle'	Xmas Present
'Petrified Heart'	Ruby
'Aquatic Mine'	Fishing Float
'Chance Totem'	6-sided die

Inspirations

- Ocarina of Time / Majora's Mask - Shop Layout, Liminal Vibes



Theme - SolarPunk

Optimistic fiction imagines a sustainable, post-capitalist future:

- Renewable energy sources such as wind, water and solar
- Maker Culture and DIY ethics
- Community collaboration and decentralization
- Decolonialism, Racial and Gender Equity



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Game Mechanics

- Each day a NPC travelling trader will visit your shop
- The player must initially trade for their items
 - Items can then be crafted or deconstructed to make scrap
- Read the item description to learn the lore of the world
 - How did the old world collapse occur and how has humanity adapted?
- Craft three end-game items to complete the game

The Shop (Empty)



The Shop (Complete)



The Items - Crafting Material

Paper Scrap	Metal Scrap	Food Scrap
Electronics Scrap	Plastic Scrap	Cloth Scrap



The Items

Grouped to explore elements leading to collapse, and how we live now

Housing Insecurity

Puffer Jacket

Sleeping Bag

Locker

Climate Collapse

Catalytic Convertor

Air Conditioner

Respirator

AI and Misinformation

Books

Hard Drive

GPU

Humanity and Dignity

Prosthesis

Birth Control

Passport

Maker Culture

Microcontroller

Wacom

3D Printer

Food and Clothing

Mystery Food

Coffee

Bunny Hug

Crystallized Focus

Instant Coffee

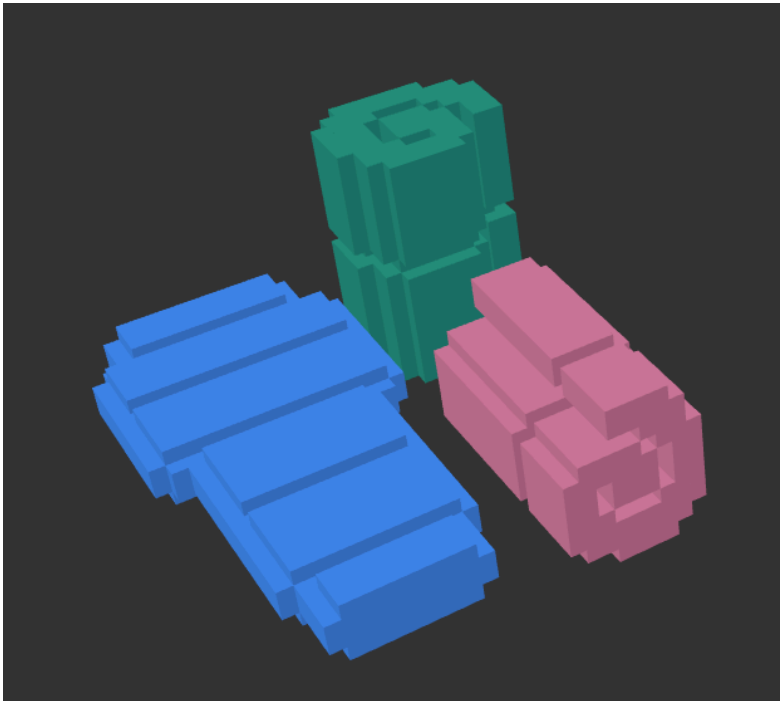


A substance from antiquity. When hydrated and drank as a liquid, it was noted for its ability to help a person complete monotonous tasks such as paperwork, which was highly prized in that society. Indeed one's ability to organize, file, and sign in triplicate, (or coerce someone else to do this upon their behalf,) were strong indications that the person would be a functioning and accepted member of society. It is so peculiar the rituals one respects and appreciates change over time. I am much more happy living in a society where one is more judged by their ability to support their neighbours and community, than complete tedious paperwork.

Today this substance is prized by artists and creators who wish to become totally immersed in their craft.

Human Cocoon

Sleeping Bag

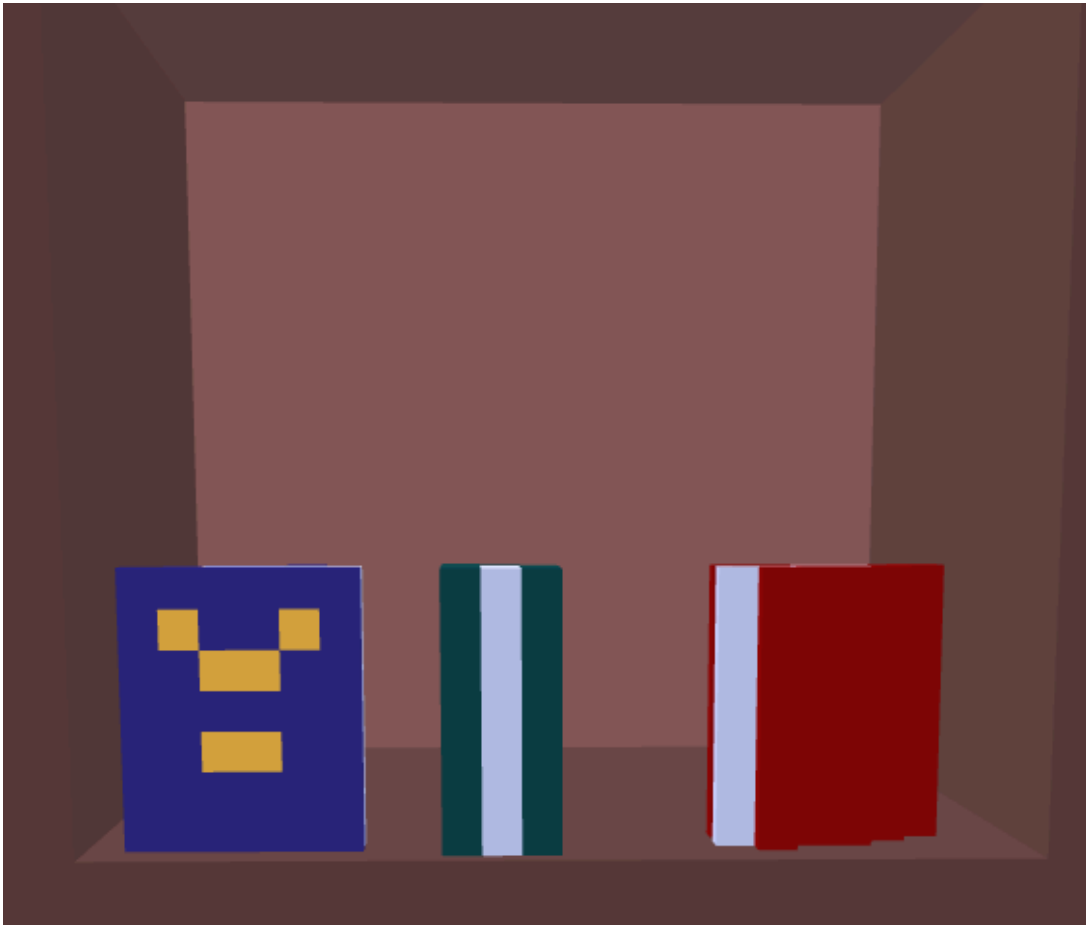


A fabric satchel for holding a person as they sleep. Created in a world when sleeping outdoors was recreation and not the norm, these quickly became a necessity as housing became artificially scarce, before groups banded together to reclaim the vacant buildings. The material traps a person's body heat within, recycling this expendable resource to fight against the cold. When an individual's body heat alone is insufficient to overcome cold climates, multiple bags can be stitched together, and body heat can be combined to fight back against lower temperatures. A friend, a lover or an animal companion can all help you overcome these savage conditions.

As a crafting material, they are a good source for finding scrap metal (zippers), cloth and plastic.

Artifact of Travel

Passport



An ancient document which in a prior age allowed individuals the right to travel between nation states. The fact that this basic human right could be granted or removed by organizational bodies baffles modern day academics. Beyond limiting this fundamental right, it is widely believed these types of documents could further restrict individuals, including stripping their right to education, their right to work, and even their right to identify their true gender. So much power taken by imaginary institutions, and yet largely unquestioned at the time.

These days this document serves as a source of paper and plastic which can be used to communicate and impart knowledge, creating freedom out of something which was once used to restrict it.

Goal Items

Indoor Garden	Water Purifier	Solar Panel
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NPCs

The travellers who visit your shop and their rotating inventory

NPC	1	2	3	4	5
Junk Bot	Canned Food	Coffee	Book	Catalytic Convertor	Passport
Tech Scavenger	Microcontroller	HDD	GPU	Wacom	3D Printer
Hiker	Bunny Hug	Puffer Jacket	Sleeping Bag	Safe	
Medic	Respirator	IUD	Prosthetic	Air Conditioner	

Crafting and/or Disassembly Table

	plastic	metal	cloth	electronic	paper	food scraps
puffer jacket	x		x			
sleeping bag		x	x			
locker	x	x				
ration		x				x
instant coffee					x	x
respirator	x		x		x	
catalytic converter		x		x		
air conditioner		x		x		
prosthetic leg	x	x				
contraceptives	x			x		
bunny hug			x			
identification					x	
book					x	
<u>gpu</u>		x		x		
hard drive		x		x		
<u>wacom</u>	x			x		
<u>microcontroller</u>		x		x		
3d printer	x	x		x		

Progress - Yellowish

Element	Completion	Status
Planning and Design	80%	Green
Player Character	80%	Green
NPCs	25%	Red
Item Models	100%	Green
Item Descriptions	30%	Red
Game Flow	50%	Yellow
Interface	0%	Red
Implementation	0%	Red

Design Challenges

- How to communicate a narrative when there is no guarantee the order players will find the items?
 - Have certain items act as bottlenecks
- How to have a climax in a game like this?
 - The goal items should prevent catharsis to the reader / player
- Softlock Prevention
 - What happens if you lock yourself out of trading goods?
 - Was thinking you might have a companion (animal/robot) who wrangles you up some scrap each night

References:

Winterson, J. (2005). *Weight: The Myth of Atlas and Heracles*. Canongate.

Cajete, G. A. (2017). Children, myth and storytelling: An Indigenous Perspective. *Global Studies of Childhood*, 7(2), 113–130.

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Questions ???